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Week in Review: June 4-10

Jeff Cunningham

Welcome to Week in Review.

Let's see what's in the news today.

Grand Prix-Amsterdam

One hundred and ninety eight teams showed up for this year's Grand Prix-Amsterdam. Almost all of Europe's established teams were present: Pheonix Foundation (Kai Budde, Marco Blume, Dirk Baberowski), Les Plus Class (although renamed something ridiculous - Gabriel Nassif, Amiel Tenenbaum, Farid Meraghni), and Object of Affection (Tomi Walamies, Anton Jonsson and Jens Thoren). There were also several new pro squads: Rankko Bongo

Wheshiwheshi (Carlos Romao, Wilfried Ranque, Jose Barbero), MagicCorporation.com (Christophe Haim, Franck Canu, Raphael Levy), and the JC Experience (John Larkin, Sam Gomersall, Patrick Mello). Finally, a few pro teams made the voyage from North America: Courtney's Men (Bob Maher, Neil Reeves, Dave Williams), Free Pat Chapin (Eddy Fear, Andy Stokinger, Mikey Pustilnik), Ace Ten Off (Jon Finkel, Eric Froelich, Kamiel Cornelissen), and TOBIT (Antonino De Rosa, Jon Sonne, Gerard Fabiano).



At the end of the first day, Belgian unknowns (except for Mats Clay), Boys of Summer topped the standings, with Object of Affection, Ranko Bongo etc., and Ace Ten Off close behind. Notably absent from the Top 20 were Courtney's Men, Kai's Gonna Get It!, and LowlandGames.com.

Since the second day was only three rounds of draft, the record required to make the Top 4 was very dependent on a strong sealed performance. Team Limited specialists Phoenix Foundation went undefeated during the second day (their Team Rochester record is somewhere in the neighborhood of 21-1) and yet still missed the Top 4. Object of Affection, Rankko Bongo, and Ace Ten Off all went 2-1 during the second day to ensure a spot in the Top 4, and the Boston Tea Party (Andre Delere, Rene Kraft, and Rolf Ottovordemgentschenfel) rounded it out.

Object of Affection fell to Ace Ten Off and Boston Tea Party fell to Rankko Bongo Wheshiweshi in the Semifinals.

The finals pitted Americans and Kamiel (Ace Ten Off) versus the ragtag assembly that was Bongo Wesh Death Squad. Despite having a stronger draft, Ace Ten Off lost to Ranko Bongo Weshi Weshi due to a tight match between Eric Froelich and Jose Barbero. In game 3, with Froelich at 10 life and having just dropped a Visara, Barbero attacked with an **Anurid Murkdiver**, and then **Torrent of Fired** Froelich out. Though Barbero would receive an Unsportsmanlike Conduct: Major warning for throwing the card in Froelich's eye, the victory stood, and Rankko Bongo Weshiweshi took the tournament!

Consensus for best name went to Hooks and Jeroen, with Peter Szigeti declaring it "by far the greatest team name ever".

The coverage for the event can be found [here](#).

Nationals: Mexico and Malaysia

So far no word of the results at these two tournaments. If you have any information regarding either event, please email me. In fact, any information about any upcoming National tournaments would be greatly appreciated. Even if you just want to hang out, email me. Hopefully, I'll have the decklists posted from these tournaments next time.

Nationals: Italy



Italy Nationals took place the weekend before last.

The Top 8 contained 3 r-g decks, an Astral Slide deck, a Psychatog deck, a Wake deck, a monoblack control deck, and an elf deck. Daniel Canavesi (r-g) defeated Fabio Savori (Astral Slide), to take the title.

The winning decklist is still as of yet unavailable. Look for it in an article on Italy Nationals by Kai, right here, tomorrow.

Noted Italian pros Andrea Dato and Raffaele Lo Moro made Top 8, along with Marco Lombardi, who finished Top 8 at last year's European Championships, but none of them made the National team.

The 2003 Italian National team is Daniel Canavesi, Fabio Savori, and Alessandro Toresan. Good luck at Worlds guys! Heck yeah!

Event Horizon Invitational

The Event Horizon Invitational, a semi-Premier invitational tournament organized to celebrate Texas Magic, took place the weekend before last. The tournament used a variety of interesting formats created solely for use in the event: 4-Way Solomon Draft,





Build a Better Mousetrap, MQ, Your Own Set of Rules, and Complete the Block. Among those competing in the event were pro players David Williams, Neil Reeves, and Grand Prix-New Orleans Top 8er Carl Lobato.

Neil Reeves, the most accomplished player competing in the tournament, eventually took the title in a one-on-one draft finals against Pro Tour-Chicago competitor Trent Boneau. It went to three games, but **Mythic Proportions** on a **Wirewood Elf** took it home.

Neil Reeves, I salute you.

I encourage you to check out the coverage [here](#).

It's My First Time, Be Gentle: Errors in Last Week's Review

Sometimes people make mistakes. Even me.

Last week I wrote my first Week in Review article, and it was brought to my attention afterwards that I made several small errors.

1. I failed to mention Thomas Rosholm in my listing of Swedish gravy trainers. Thomas is a long-standing member of Team Bjorksele (with Anton Jonsson and Mattias Kettil). His last report can be found [here](#).
2. The format of German Nationals was not actually three rounds Standard, six rounds of draft, three rounds of Standard as I mentioned, it was standard six rounds Standard, six rounds of draft.
3. There are actually two fewer ways to kill your opponent on your Turn 1 before your upkeep than I originally thought.
4. I would like to make a clarification. In last week's Play of the Week, Manny Orellana had not announced **Form of the Dragon** (put it on the stack), he had only begun to lay the card down. All of Mike's shenanigans would have been for naught if the spell had actually been committed to the stack, but it had not, and his "play" was perfectly legal.
5. I failed to note my sources for German and Swedish Nationals. You can find information on German Nationals [here](#), and Swedish Nationals [here](#).
6. Peter Radonjic's name is spelt as such, not "Rajdonic" as I misspelled it. Yes, I do have a learning disability.
7. The comparison between the German team and the Finnish team is actually much closer than I thought. Subtract the National Champions from the equation, and the Finnish team outnumbers the German team in lifetime pro points by 65! The current favorite for Worlds could well be the Finnish team.
8. There were actually only eight decks in the Top 8 of Swedish Nationals, not ten as I wrote. The eight were: three Wake, one 'Tog, one u-g, two monoblack control and one g-b.
9. Gary Talim's favorite color is not, in fact, pink.

10. There is no Darryl Snaggletooth. There never was a Darryl Snaggletooth. Whoever says there was is lying. Forget Darryl Snaggletooth.

Back in Action: Searing Flesh

By now, everyone knows about Peter Szigeti's infamous ["Searing Flesh heard 'round the world"](#). In case you haven't, though, I'll sum it up: Peter Szigeti, Pro Tour ne'er-do-well, after top-decking **Searing Flesh** for the win, wiped his posterior with it and presented it to his startled opponent. Afterwards, Szigeti was given a match loss for Unsportsmanlike Conduct, costing him several hundred dollars, and a heckuva lot of pride.

Many thought Szigeti would never Flesh again.

However, the story has a happy ending. This past weekend, at a Costa Mesa *Onslaught* Block Grand Prix Trial, Szigeti played a monored deck that featured 4 **Searing Fleshes**, including the very one that got him the match loss (just to show that there were no hard feelings)! He piloted the Flesh-laden deck to a Top 4 spot. He didn't get the byes, but he had a lot of fun, and began the critical healing process.



Magic Trivia

What *Odyssey* Block Constructed deck did four-time Pro Tour Top 8er Benedict Klauser design?

Play of the Week

In the Finals of this year's Polish nationals, Ola Rogula was playing against Radoslaw Gromko for the title. Rogula was playing u-g madness, and Gromko was with monoblack control.



It was the deciding game, and although Gromko had superior board position, and was still at 15 life, Rogula had 4 (!) **Composts** and a freshly plucked **Wild Mongrel** in play. Unfortunately, she had 0 cards in hand. Gromko attacked Rogula with a fully pumped **Nantuko Shade**, putting her down to eight life, and passed the turn.

Rogula untapped, and drew her card - **Quiet Speculation**. Double-checking the card, she played the spell, targeting Gromko and pulled 3 **Chainer's Edicts** from his library, drawing 12 cards off the **Composts**! One of those was a **Deep Analysis**, and when flashed back, her 15/15 Mongrel furiously ripped into the red zone and viciously tore out Radoslaw Gromko's throat, in a furious and vicious-like manner!

Ola Rogula, I award you Play of the Week!

Putting Ancestral to shame.

Bad Play of the Week: Mishap in Mainz

"Last weekend, German Nationals was held in Mainz, Germany. The tournament brought out all of the old-guard German pros, such as Frank Adler and Peer Kroger. However, after 11 grueling rounds, Kai Budde was primed for another Top 8. Not only was he the returning champion, but he was the heavy favorite. With only two rounds left, there was little doubt in anyone's mind that the German Juggernaut was going to retain his throne, and continue his conquest of America. In game 3 of Round 11, Andre Muller scooped up his cards in defeat. Kai went through the motions, the handshake, the signing of the match slip, and the obligatory revealing of the morphs. Kai revealed his **Daru Sanctifier**, the only problem was that it was a **Whipgrass Entangler**! Unfortunately for Kai, (and very fortunately for the U.S. team), at some point in the game he had misplayed. Kai received a game loss, and missed Top 8. The United Arab Emirates are early favorites to take home the title in Berlin."



Nope, it doesn't morph, even if you are the best player in the world.

Kai Budde, I award you Bad Play of the Week!

Quote of the Week

"I cast a **Drain Life**... upon you... for forty. In response, I **Pyroblast** both of your creatures." Mike Long, Class Act, Semifinals U.S. Nationals 1999.

Next Week

- Nationals: Venezuela, Philippines, Brazil (plus Mexico and Malaysia recap!)
- Canada Nationals Preview: Spotlight on Jeff Cunningham: the man, the myth, the legend.
- Aunt Abigale bakes peanut brittle.
- **Magic Online** Clan Wars: Supernova to be usurped by new titan Tin Can Telephones?

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